

system, a rite of passage for most teenagers who've fallen in love with music. And it's never been enough for teens just to hear music. They have to have the perfect sound system on which to play their music, even if the system takes up a significant corner of their bedrooms and the speakers shake the very foundation of their parents' house.

The entire system I wanted back then cost \$4,000. That's a lot of money now, but it was a fortune back then—the price of a brand-new domestic car. But when I imagined showing this system off to my friends, I factored that feeling into the price tag. I wasn't conscious of the high price of the brag factor back then, but I pay attention to it today, especially as a parent of two teenagers.

I didn't have \$4,000 at age seventeen. I did have \$1,700, about a month's pay from my glamorous garbage truck-cleaning gig. The salesman at the stereo store bent forward and scratched his head when I told him how much I had. He wanted that \$1,700. So he did what every good salesperson does to part you from your money. He talked to me as though I already owned this incredible stereo system, implying that the \$1,700 was a small, inconvenient, but necessary step in that process.

"That's no problem. I'll cut the price to \$3,500 and you're halfway there with the down payment. You take your system home today, the rest you pay later."

These are magical words that go along with magical mathematical thinking, right? "No problem," "down payment," "pay later." I was sold. Another month of hosing off garbage trucks and this thing would be mine. And how sweet to be able to leave the store with this dream system—today! Right now!

I piled the car full of the carefully packed boxes and headed home. I cleared a corner of my bedroom and began to lovingly assemble my new stereo system. It was a beautiful moment. When everything was set up, I carefully placed the precision needle into the groove of my Emerson, Lake and Palmer album. The sound was crystalline, gorgeous, pure—as though I had bought a dozen angels and suspended them over my bed to sing right at me. My parents heard the angels and came to my bedroom door. They didn't look nearly as